

Apple's new "AI answers" team explained

Is it a Google rival in the making in the long term?

—By **Vyom Ramani**

Apple is quietly assembling what could be its most ambitious artificial intelligence project yet. Internally dubbed the Answers, Knowledge, and Information (AKI) team, this new unit is focused on building a smart, conversational "answer engine" designed to rival Google Search, ChatGPT, and other similar generative AI platforms and tools.

Unlike Siri's past attempts at voice-based help, which often ended with "Here's what I found on the web," this is Apple's shot at building a true knowl-

edge assistant. One that doesn't just fetch information, but understands it, explains it clearly, and tailors responses to the context in which the user has asked questions, all while staying within Apple's strict privacy guardrails.

is broader: create an AI system that can understand complex user queries, retrieve relevant knowledge from the internet and the user's personal data, and do so naturally and securely. The AI this team is developing isn't just for Siri. It's expected to show up across the Apple ecosystem in Spotlight, Safari, Mail, Messages, Calendar, and possibly even as a standalone app in the future. This omnipresence is where Apple's real edge lies: while Google dominates web search, Apple controls the environment in which a billion users spend their digital lives.

At first glance, trying to compete with Google in search may seem futile. After all, Google processes billions of

queries daily and has a two-decade lead in crawling, indexing, and ranking the internet over all its competitors.

For example, instead of Googling "how to get to my doctor's appointment," you could just ask Siri or Spotlight, and it would already know which appointment, where it is, and suggest the best route based on your usual preferences and traffic.

If executed well, this kind of deeply integrated, hyper-personalized AI could potentially change how people think about information retrieval entirely, shifting from generic search to meaningful, contextual answers.

Privacy as a competitive advantage

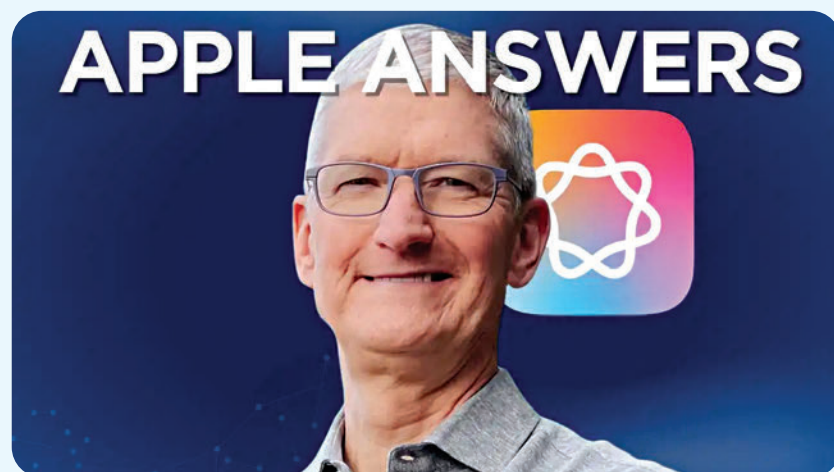
What truly sets Apple's approach apart is its privacy model. Unlike Google, which monetizes search through ads and data collection, Apple is building its AI using on-device models and a new secure cloud system called Private Cloud Compute. This means most of your interactions stay on your device or are encrypted in transit.

In a time when trust in Big Tech is eroding, Apple's AI pitch is simple but powerful: "We don't know who you are, and that's the point." If it can deliver performance comparable to Google and OpenAI while keeping data local, that's a very appealing alternative for millions.

The AI Answers team is still in its early stages, with major updates expected to roll out in iOS 27 and the broader Siri reboot in 2026. Until then, Apple continues to rely on external models like ChatGPT, and is reportedly exploring partnerships with Anthropic, Google, and Perplexity AI.

But the formation of the AKI team signals a long-term ambition: Apple doesn't just want to utilise the interface, but also own the brain behind it. It doesn't just want to display results, it wants to be the trusted source of answers across your digital life.

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A smarter Siri or a Google Search Rival?

The AKI project is led by Robby Walker, a veteran of Apple's Siri team who has publicly acknowledged the assistant's early shortcomings. His new mandate

queries daily and has a two-decade lead in crawling, indexing, and ranking the internet over all its competitors.

But Apple isn't trying to build another Google. It's trying to redefine what search means for the individual user. Where Google's strength lies in offering global answers, Apple's advantage could be contextual understanding. Through system-level access to apps like Notes, Calendar, Mail, and Photos, Apple can offer answers that combine public knowledge with private context.